

Playing with Trumps

One suit gets special power: a player out of the suit led can win the trick with a trump.



1 Trumps, ruffs and fits

To ruff: to win a trick with a trump when you have no cards left in the suit led.

Fit: your side holds at least 8 cards in a suit. A trump contract pays when your side holds more trumps than the opponents.

Even a weak suit pays as trumps: with ♥ QJ10987 you take at least 4 tricks.

In the trump suit, cards sure to be established count as winners.

2 Drawing trumps

NORTH	
♠	874
♥	109
♦	KQJ2
♣	AK63
WEST	
♠	AKQ92
♥	432
♦	63
♣	1052
EAST	
♠	J1065
♥	86
♦	10987
♣	QJ4
SOUTH	
♠	3
♥	AKQJ75
♦	A54
♣	987

4♥ · West leads the A♠ and K♠

South ruffs the K♠. Cashing the diamonds at once, West would ruff the third round. First **three rounds of hearts** to draw the defenders' trumps, then the diamonds safely: **12 tricks**, 6 hearts, 4 diamonds, 2 clubs. In notrump South would have lost the first five.

Side-suit winners are only relative: cash them safely only after drawing trumps.

Control: by ruffing, South stopped West's spades. No trick was gained: 5 hearts cashed plus 1 ruff still make 6.

3 Ruffing in the short hand

NORTH	
♠	1095
♥	4
♦	A762
♣	A10842
WEST	
♠	2
♥	KJ87
♦	J1054
♣	KQJ7
EAST	
♠	864
♥	Q10952
♦	Q83
♣	93
SOUTH	
♠	AKQJ73
♥	A63
♦	K9
♣	65

4♠ · West leads the K♣

Winners: 6 spades, 1 heart, 2 diamonds, 1 club. But spades can produce **8 tricks** instead of 6, ruffing with dummy's trumps:

1. A♣, A♥ and a heart ruffed in dummy.
2. A spade to a high honor in hand, then a heart ruffed in dummy.
3. Back to hand with the K♦, draw trumps, A♦: **12 tricks**.

Don't always draw trumps at once: first take the ruffs in the short hand, the one with fewer trumps.

A ruff gains only if it adds at least one trick to what the suit would give anyway.

4 Establishing with ruffs

NORTH	♠ KJ4	♥ A7	♦ 65	♣ A98753
SOUTH	♠ AQ8652	♥ 986	♦ A3	♣ K2

4♠ · West leads the K♦

In a trump contract you can establish a long suit **without losing the lead**: the low cards you would have to lose get ruffed instead.

1. A♦, two rounds of trumps.
2. K♣, A♣ and a club ruffed in hand: if the opponents' clubs split 3-2, they all fall.
3. Dummy's three clubs are good, with the **ace of hearts** as the entry: **13 tricks**.